“Who Is Supposed to Be Handling This?” Eight Questions Families Ask in the First Days of a Care Situation

Plain, general answers, and who to ask when the question is about Dad himself.

Somewhere between the third phone call and the fifth, many families start circling the same few questions. Here are eight of them, answered in general terms.

General is the limit of this page. Anything that turns on Dad himself, his health or what should happen next, belongs with someone who knows him, and each answer names who that is.

1 Who is supposed to be handling all of this?

Often nobody has been named yet, and that's ordinary. The Family Caregiver Alliance notes that families often don't think through who becomes the primary caregiver and what supporting roles the others will play. AARP's planning guide suggests a point person: someone who keeps the process moving and makes sure people understand what's been decided. The roadmap asks you to name one family contact for now, and a backup. [1] [2]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** you can't tell who on the care team is coordinating Dad's care. Ask them directly, and write down the name and number.

2 Everyone wants to know what happened. Do I have to keep retelling it?

No. Write it once (what happened, the day, who was there, and what has been said since), then read or send the same few lines to each person who asks. A written account stays the same from one telling to the next. The Family Caregiver Alliance notes that email can keep even relatives who aren't nearby up to date. [3] [4]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** you aren't sure who on the care team should have your written account. The Alliance says a discharge planner will look to the caregiver for history and insights, so ask who would like a copy.

3 What counts as “what changed”?

The event or change that started this, and whatever is different since: where Dad is staying, who is helping, how his day goes. Write what changed and when, in order, and note beside each line whether you saw it yourself or were told. What a change means for his health is more than a family's notes can say.

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** you want to know what a change means for Dad's health or for the weeks ahead. That's a question for his doctor.

4 How do we know which decision we actually have to make?

Three things blur together in a busy week: how things are arranged now, what someone has proposed, and what the family must actually decide. Separate them, then write the decision as one sentence with any date you were given and who gave it. If Dad is in the hospital, Medicare's discharge checklist tells patients and caregivers to ask where care will be given after discharge and whether there are options, and to tell the staff what they prefer. [5]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** you aren't sure which decision comes first, or whether a date is firm. Ask the person who gave it to you.

5 My brother and I remember it differently. Whose version goes on the page?

Both. The Family Caregiver Alliance says it's natural for siblings to take in a situation at different times and in different ways, and that parents often tell their children different things about how they're doing. Write each account with the name of the person who gave it, and don't try to settle the difference yourselves. Where nobody knows, write “not yet known” instead of a best guess. [1]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** the two accounts differ about Dad's health. The Alliance notes that professionals outside the family, such as physicians and social workers, can help siblings establish what is real about a parent's health and needs.

6 We're all doing bits and pieces. How do we see who is doing what?

Make one list of the tasks, put a name beside each, and confirm each one with the person named. The Family Caregiver Alliance suggests that caregivers list all the things they do, both for their own clarification and for family members who may not be aware of their efforts. It also notes that siblings may assume the one who is helping has everything covered, so ask that person which parts are becoming difficult. [6] [1] [2]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** the list raises a question about what help Dad needs. AARP's guide says a nurse or social worker can help determine what is needed.

7 Should Dad be part of this?

Yes, wherever he can be. AARP's planning guide says a family caregiving plan must center on the wishes of the person receiving the care, and should never be made without that person's participation, knowledge and consent. The Family Caregiver Alliance adds that the person being cared for usually does not want to be left out of family events, and that their preferences for care must be considered. The roadmap asks you to review the page with Dad where possible, and to keep what he says he wants separate from what the family wants for him. [2] [3]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** you're unsure how much Dad is able to take part right now. Ask his doctor or nurse.

8 Will the doctors and nurses talk to us about Dad?

Start with Dad's permission. The National Institute on Aging advises caregivers to make sure a person's health care providers have permission to speak with them. Dad can tell the doctor that he agrees, and most doctors' offices and hospitals have a consent form for naming who may receive a person's medical information. The same goes for any existing care notes you'd like to gather: ask first. [7]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** you need to know what a particular office requires. Ask that office for its form.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't answer any question about Dad himself. Whether he is safe where he is, what help he needs and which option the family should choose all depend on someone who has assessed him.

Ready for the next step?

You have plain answers to the questions your family keeps circling. The care interview is where the questions become about Dad: it walks you through his situation area by area and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

1. Family Caregiver Alliance, Caregiving with Your Siblings
2. AARP, Prepare to Care: A Planning Guide for Families
3. Family Caregiver Alliance, Holding a Family Meeting
4. Family Caregiver Alliance, Hospital Discharge Planning: A Guide for Families and Caregivers
5. Medicare (Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services), Your discharge planning checklist
6. Family Caregiver Alliance, Caregiving 101: On Being a Caregiver
7. National Institute on Aging (NIH), Taking Someone to a Doctor’s Appointment: Tips for Caregivers

From the Family Care Roadmap · Richard Ladson, Certified Medicaid Planner. Draft for review, generated 2026-10-04.